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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Men and women from the Gurung (Tamu) community performing cultural dance on the occasion of Tamu Lhosar at Tundikhel in Kathmandu on Sunday.

Lhosar oldest festival of the world: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that Lhosar, an important festival of the Tamu (Gurung) community, is the oldest cultural festival in the world.

While inaugurating the festival of Tamu Lhosar in Tundikhel on Sunday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the festival carried scientific importance as it was linked with the annual motion of the earth.

He said that the festival was an integral part of the national festival.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that the Gurung community started celebrating Lhosar in connection with the movement for rights after the establishment of the multi-party system in Nepal in 1990. He said the characteristics of multi-caste, multi-language, multi-religion and multi-culture formed the backbone of nationalism.

The festival is also celebrated in China, Mongolia, Vietnam, Korea, Bhutan, Thailand, Burma and other countries, the Prime Minister said. "However, it is celebrated differently in these countries," he added.

He further said that the constitution of Nepal has institutionalised national unity and identity based on diversity. "It is our national task to achieve the goal of prosperity with national unity by deeply imbibing this meaning and spirit of the Constitution. Nepal is a meeting place of major civilisations of East, West, North and South," he said.

All the castes/tribes living here have their different traditions, customs and cultures, he said.

"The totality and integrated nature of all these cultures constitute the national culture of Nepal," the Prime Minister said, adding, "Meanwhile, the government has been continuously striving to achieve the national aspiration of development while addressing the existing challenges in the country."

A large number of people from the Gurung community attired in their traditional dresses thronged Tundikhel to mark the festival. They presented several cultural programmes throughout the day. A food festival was also organised on the occasion with various stalls displaying foods popular in the Gurung community.

On the occasion, CPN (Maoist Centre) General Secretaries, Tamu Hyula Chhonj Dhin Gurung Rastriya Parishad Central Chairperson, Indigenous Nationalities Commission members, National Natural Resources and

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PM INSTRUCTS TO FORM HIGH-LEVEL PANEL TO PROBE BALKUMARI INCIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Home Affairs to bring a proposal to form a high-level commission to investigate the shooting and killing of two youths in Balkumari of Lalitpur district.

The commission would be formed under the chairmanship of a former justice in accordance with sub-section (2) of section 3 of the Commission of Inquiry Act, 1969 to investigate the incident, according to the Prime Minister's Office.

A Cabinet meeting that would be convened on Monday will make a formal decision about the commission and the latter would start its work on the same day, read a statement issued by the PM's secretariat on Sunday.

Birendra Shah, 22, and Sujan Rawat, 23, were killed in a clash with the police at Balkumari on Friday.

A group of youths had been demonstrating at Balkumari saying that they shouldn't be barred from sitting in the

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New Year Greetings

The Rising Nepal family extends its best wishes and greetings to our valued readers, advertisers and well-wishers on the occasion of New Year 2024.

73 protestors held from Balkumari released

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

Police have released 73 protestors who were arrested during the demonstration at Balkumari in Lalitpur on Friday.

Deputy Inspector General and Spokesperson for the Nepal Police Headquarters, Kuber Kadayat said that those who were arrested during the demonstration demanding to be allowed to fill out Employment Permit System (EPS) language test applications to go to Korea have been released on Sunday.

According to DIG Kadayat, all those who were put in various police stations after the demonstration were released.

He said, "All those arrested during the demonstration have been released and it has been decided not to file any case against them."

They were arrested and detained by the police on charge of setting fire to the vehicle of Physical Infrastructure and Transport Minister Prakash Jwala and vandalising public property on Friday.

Two youths, 23-year-old Sujan Rawat of Mahabu Rural Municipality-6 of Dailekh, and 22-year-old Birendra Shah of Chowrapati Rural Municipality-1 of Acham, died during the demonstration.

The government has also decided to provide relief amount of Rs. 1 million each to the families of Rawat and Shah who lost their lives.

The government has also expressed its sorrow and taken departmental action on those officials including CDO Rudra Prasad Pandit and SSP Siddhi Bikram Shah of Lalitpur, for not being able to properly control the demonstration.

Sudurpashchim govt to give Rs. 200,000 to family of deceased Shah

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sudurpaschim, Dec. 31

The Sudurpashchim government has decided to give Rs. 200,000 as compensation to the family of 22-year-old Birendra Shah, who was killed in the Balkumari incident on Friday.

Shah, a resident of Chaurapati Rural Municipality of Achham, was shot dead during the protest staged by Korean language test candidates demanding that they should be allowed to appear for the language test for jobs in the manufacturing sector in South Korea.

Chief Minister Kamal Bahadur Shah said that the Sudurpashchim government was deeply saddened by Shah's death and has decided to provide compensation to the bereaved family.

Meanwhile, a protest was held in front of the office of the Chief Minister and the Council of Ministers in Dhangadhi on Sunday, demanding action against the culprit involved in killing Shah.

Bharat Bahadur Shah, a relative of the deceased, said that the protestors have put eight-point demands, including that the body of the deceased should be brought to Achham, Shah should be declared a martyr and proper compensation should be provided to the family.

NC to pick deserving candidates for NA election

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

The Nepali Congress has said it will give priority to popular and capable persons who have not had any opportunity to date while picking the candidates for National Assembly member election.

A meeting of the NC Central Working Committee that concluded on Saturday night decided to pick the candidates for the NA election based on the standards of maintaining geographical, ethnic and regional balance and the candidates should have a clean image and possess the ability to contribute to the parliamentary exercise.

Organising a press meet at the party central office Sanepa of Lalitpur on Sunday to inform about the decisions of the three-day CWC meeting, NC Publicity Department chief Meen Bishwokarma said the party also decided to forge consensus among ruling coalition parties for the NA election and pick common candidates.

The election for 19 NA members is slated for January 25.

The party called on all to conclude the remaining task of the peace process to provide justice to conflict affected persons and their families.

The party demanded for formulation of acts relating to civil servants, federal police, school education and others to implement the constitution keeping in view the demands of the provincial governments.

Ministers of the federal government inducted from the NC briefed the meeting about their performance and their role.

CWC members underlined the need for more work from the government to fully encourage the people by analysing the tasks of the past year in development activities, governance, employment promotion, and prosperity.

Bishwokarma said the meeting also decided to draw the attention of the government to ensure peace and security and adopt effective policies for good governance as people are not experiencing good governance and transparency.

The meeting demanded that the government take effective policies

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Danfe spotted in unusually lower altitude in Manang

BY YADU PRASAD BHATT
Manang, Dec. 31



The Himalayan Monal, known as Danfe in Nepali, has been spotted in Dharapani of Naso Rural Municipality in the district.

The bird, which is national bird of Nepal and typically found only in the high Himalayas, is now venturing into lower elevations. Faced with abundant snow in the mountains and a scarcity of food, birds like Danfe are descending in search of nutrition.

In all wards of Naso, it does not snow. The rural municipality is taken as heaven compared to other rural municipalities in the district. But only a few hoteliers and local representatives visit the village this wintertime. Others are escaping the cold in cities like Kathmandu, Pokhara, and surrounding areas.

During this peaceful time, the bird was spotted at the Eco Himalayan Hotel at Dharapani of Ward No. 2 of Naso Rural Municipality-2.

Thuten Lama, Chairperson of Ward No. 5 of the rural municipality, said it might be chased away by eagle so it came to our homes. "It being a national bird, we need to take care of it and protect its habitat," he said.

He said that the Danfe that came to the Eco Himalayan Hotel is now under the care of Kiran Gurung, the hotel manager. The bird has been handed over to Rabi Gurung, Chairperson of Ward No. 2 in the presence of Ward Member Nisha Gurung.

Gurung assumed that the Danfe settlement could be near the Annapurna Conservation Area (ACA) since it is nearby.

New Year revellers throng Kanyam, Sri Antu

BY PREM ADHIKARI
Pashupatinagar (Ilam), Dec. 31



Like in previous years, Kanyam and Sri Antu in the Ilam district have become popular destinations for the New Year revellers. This was evident from the crowd of people who thronged these two destinations on the eve of New Year on Sunday.

Kanyam and Antu remained popular destinations throughout the year, attracting a large number of tourists in all seasons. More visitors are arriving to explore and enjoy these renowned tourist spots for the New Year 2024 celebrations.

Visitors from various districts of Nepal, as well as Indian tourists, have already secured their accommodations in advance. Rudra Ghimire, President of the Antu Tourism Entrepreneurs Association, said that the flow of tourists to celebrate the New Year is expected to rise this time.

The majority of hotels, homestays, and cottages in Antu have been booked for Saturday and Monday. Ghimire added, "This time, more than 60 per cent of visitors arriving in Antu are from India."

Tourists from neighbouring Indian cities like Gangtok in Sikkim, and Mirik, Siliguri and Darjeeling of West Bengal state of India have already made hotel reservations. Bengali tourists have also been increasingly choosing to visit Antu and Kanyam in recent times.

Antu boasts over 64 community and private homestays, along with the operation of more than 50 small hotels and cottages. Some 3,500 to 4,000 tourists have already booked hotels in Antu, Ghimire added.

Tourists visit Antu mainly to enjoy the view of the sunrise. They also enjoy activities such as boating in Antu Pond, exploring tea gardens and horse riding. From Antu, one can enjoy stunning views of mountains, including Kanchenjunga, the third-highest peak in the world, and Kumbhakarna.

Dhan Kumar Ale, a homestay businessman, shared that tourists were attracted to homestays featuring beautifully decorated wooden houses within tea gardens and flower gardens, showcasing local products.

Gajendra Upreti, a local tourist visiting Antu, said that no matter how many times he visited, the charm of Antu and Kanyam never ceased to attract him.

Kanyam is also bustling with tourists. Tekraj Giri, a hotelier in Kanyam, said that the place is currently packed with tourists. Giri said that for the past four to five years, the new years of the Nepali and Gregorian calendars have been celebrated in Kanyam as major festivals. Tourists from two neighbouring countries are joyfully engaged in New Year celebrations.

Tourists in Kanyam also enjoy diverse experiences, dressing up in costumes of different castes, taking pictures, and tasting tea. Suryodaya Municipality has added attractions like a Selfie Park and skywalk with private investments to cater to the tourists.

Tourists enjoy Kanyam late into the night. Roshan Sharma, a visitor from Darjeeling, India, comes every year to celebrate the New Year in Kanyam and Sri Antu. The beautification efforts by Suryodaya Municipality have attracted more tourists to the area.

Rana Bahadur Rai, Mayor of Suryodaya Municipality, said that Antu and Kanyam, popular among domestic tourists, have recently gained popularity among international tourists as well.

We're ready to pay electricity dues: Industrialists

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

Industrialists have said that they are ready to pay the dues for electricity consumption if the Nepal Electricity Authority produces credible proof.

In a press conference led by the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) on Sunday, they claimed that they did not use the facilities of dedicated and trunk lines provided by the NEA, but they were ready to pay the dues if the Authority provided evidence.

"We are not in favour of going to court and prolonging the standoff, we have a humble request to NEA to provide the TOD meter data. If the NEA gives proof of consuming electricity through dedicated and trunk lines during load-shedding, we want to pay the fee," said Pashupati Murarka, former President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry.

He said that the right of the Nepal Electricity Authority was not to set tariffs but to collect them. He questioned why no action was taken against the customers who used electricity without obtaining permission for dedicated and trunk line facilities, saying that they had paid their regular bills on time. "Please show the proof, we are ready to pay. If we don't follow the law by not paying the bill, we will be part of it," he said.



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Nepal Electricity Authority

"'Who will be responsible for the damage caused to the industry due to the stress caused to us by sending the electricity bill that we have not used and the power supply cut?" He said that the Authority had issued fake bills without taking action against those who used electricity without permission as per the Electricity Theft Control Act.

On the occasion, president of CNI Rajesh Agrawal said that the line of industries was cut even though they were saying that they would pay the dues of the dedicated and trunk lines if the NEA presented proof of electricity consumption.

"This issue has been disputed for a long time, some industries have gone to the court, but it has not yet been resolved. In such a situation, cutting the power of the manufacturing and export-oriented industries operating at low capacity will have a negative impact on the overall economy and will send a negative message of the national image," Agrawal said.

He said that the Authority cut the power supply of the industries by treating operation of industry as a crime. Agrawal asked the government to resolve the problems of dedicated and trunk line at the earliest by reconnecting lines of those industries which are cut.

The NEA cut electricity supply of 23 industries getting power supply from dedicated feeder and trunk lines. According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

Anjan Shrestha, senior vice-president of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, said the industrialists are ready to pay the dues if the NEA presented evidence on the issue. He complained that the industrialists were treated like criminals.

The industrialists said that according to the bills issued by the Authority, most of the industries are paying the bill regularly and are also taking a 2 per cent discount facility. Earlier, the business community met the Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and requested to resolve the problem by forming a high-level committee at the earliest.

MATATIRTHA-PHARPING ROAD TO REMAIN CLOSED FOR TWO MONTHS

RSS
Makwanpur, Dec. 31

The Matatirtha and Phakhel-Pharping road sections in the Indrasarobar rural municipality of Makwanpur are closing for vehicular traffic for a two-month period for upgrading works. The Kulekhani-Humane-Phakhel section and the Humane-Matatirtha section, which serve as an approach road to Teku in Kathmandu, will be inaccessible until February 28, starting tomorrow, according to the Indrasarobar rural municipality.

To mitigate the inconvenience for commuters, alternative routes have been arranged during the closure period. Deepak Chapagain, the information officer for the rural municipality, suggests using the Hetaunda-Bhimphedi-Kulekhani-Sisneri-Dakshinkali route and the Kulekhani-Markhu-Chitlang-Thankot route as alternatives for travel.

Beneficiaries receive first installment of assistance



RSS
Tribeni (Rukum West), Dec. 31

The people affected by the November 3 earthquake in Rukum West have received the first installment of monetary assistance meant for building temporary shelters. They numbered 19,717.

According to an official source, so far 19,717 beneficiaries at all six local levels in the district have received Rs 25,000 each, totaling Rs 492 million 925 thousand. Assistant Chief District Officer, Prabesh Baduwal, said though the District Disaster Management Fund allocated the budget for 23,600 eligible beneficiaries, the Local Disaster Mitigation Fund distributed it to 19,717.

The highest number of beneficiaries is from the Aathbiskot municipality as they numbered 7,000. The affected in Banfikot rural municipality have been unable to get the assistance amount in absence of the chief administrative officer at the local government, it is said.

In Chaurjahari municipality, the number of beneficiaries is 5,938 beneficiaries while it is 211 in Musikot municipality, 4,449 in Sanibheri rural municipality and 2,069 in Triveni rural municipality.

The District Disaster Fund allocated RS 590,200,000 to the local fund and the first installment has yet to be received by 3,091 beneficiaries. The District Administration Office has said that it has so far identified above 28,800 as beneficiaries for the earthquake assistance.

EIA of two industrial zones initiated

RSS
Gandaki, Dec. 31

Works have been initiated for conducting the environmental impact assessment (EIA) of the industrial zone at Punditar of Kaski and at Lokahakhola of Nawalpur. The Gandaki province government had announced the construction of these two projects six years back. Gaumukhi Engineering had got the responsibility of conducting the EIA of these two projects.

The agreement to this effect was signed with the consultant company two weeks back and it has started its works, said Ram Prasad Acharya, Chief of the Industry-Commerce Division at the Ministry of Industry, Tourism, Forest and Environment, the Sudurpaschim government. "The consulting firm has been given the responsibility of determining the area of work and preparing the list of works within one month, and submitting the preliminary report within two months and the final report within five months," he added.

According to Acharya, the provincial government has forwarded the works related to environmental impact assessment as the federal government does not provide the land for the industrial area until the EIA is conducted. He shared that the construction of industrial zone had not started since the land for the facilities could not be managed even for many years since the industrial zone was declared.

Acharya said the proposal sent by the provincial government for acquiring the land for the two projects has been pending at the Ministry of Forests and Environment of the Federal government. "The process of managing land would move ahead after the EIA report is submitted. After that, the Ministry will concentrate on constructing the infrastructures required for the industrial zone," he added.

As he said, the proposal sent by the provincial government has already reached the Ministry of Forests and Environment of the Federal Government from the Office of the Council of Ministers and the Council of Ministers will make a decision to provide land for the industrial zone after getting the approval of the Ministry of Forests and Environment. The provincial government has allocated Rs 25 million in this fiscal year for the construction of the industrial zone.

US seizes illegal e-cigarettes, allows new companies

AP
Washington, Dec.31

Federal officials are seizing more shipments of unauthorized electronic cigarettes at U.S. ports, but thousands of new flavored products continue pouring into the country from China.

The figures underscore the chaotic state of the nation's $7 billion vaping market and raise questions about how the U.S. government can stop the flow of fruit-flavored disposable e-cigarettes used by 1 in 10 American teens and adolescents.

More than 11,500 unique vaping products are being sold in U.S. stores, up 27% from 9,000 products in June, according to tightly held industry data from analytics firm Circana.

"FDA whacks one product and then the manufacturers get around it and the kids get around it," said Bonnie Halpern-Felsher, a Stanford University psychologist who develops anti-vaping educational materials. "It's too easy to change your product a little bit and just relaunch it."

Halpern-Felsher says she is "constantly" updating her curriculum to keep pace with new vaping brands and trends. Nearly all the new products are disposable e-cigarettes, according to the sales data gathered from gas stations, convenience stores and other shops. The products generated $3.2 billion in the first 11 months of this year.

The FDA has authorized a handful of e-cigarettes for adult smokers and is still reviewing products from several major companies, including Juul. Regulators consider nearly all other e-cigarettes to be illegal.

"Those committing illegal acts don't advertise their crimes, and those trying to import illegal tobacco products into the United States are no different," said FDA's tobacco director, Brian King, in a written response to AP questions. "The FDA and our federal partners are using tools, like import alerts, to stop these illegal tobacco products at the border and to deter countless others."

The rise in e-cigarettes sold continues despite a record number of products detained. An FDA database shows officials "refused" entry to 148 containers or pallets of "tobacco" goods last month, consisting almost entirely of vaping products from China. Refused imports are typically destroyed.



PHOTO: DIWAKAR POKHAREL/TRN

Rafting introduced in the Rapti River is becoming popular in Dang.

Ilam farmer happy after his orange orchard earns Rs. 1 million



PHOTO: KOKILA DHAKAL/TRN

Sambed Chapagain, a farmer of Ilam in his oranges garden.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ilam, Dec. 31

Sambed Chapagain, a farmer of Ilam Municipality-5, spends his days caring for ripe oranges around his orchard. Chapagain, who started orange cultivation in 2003, sold his orange orchard for Rs. 1 million this season. He is happy with the income.

He recalled, "I had sold this orchard at Rs. 3,000 when these trees bore fruit for the first time. Now I get surprised recalling those days." However, he said many of the orange gardens of the past year had been destroyed for various reasons including diseases.

He said that income from the sale of oranges this year was unexpected. He said he had the same orange garden at Rs. 400,000 last year. Farmers in Ilam sell the orange trees instead of harvesting the fruit to the traders every year.

"After the production started decreasing, the traders started increasing orange prices." Chapagain said, "I reach the orchard in the morning and stay in the garden till evening, taking care of the oranges, weeding, controlling pest and irrigating the garden.

Chapagai, who has planted oranges on about 18 ropanis of land, is now removing the dried plants and adding new plants. "I want to make an impressive orange garden; I am working on it," he said.

This is the main season of oranges. The retail price of oranges, which have started appearing in the market since the second week of Kartik, now ranges from Rs. 120 to Rs. 150 per kg.

However, most of the gardens have dried up, he added. The farmers are worried as the production of oranges decreases due to the drying up of the trees every year.

The farmers said that the production of oranges has decreased this year compared to last year. They said that even in five-six-year-old adult plants, the seeds turn yellow in the bud, insects get inside them and the plant turns yellow and dries up, so it is unable to treat it.

Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Ilam, has also reported that the production of oranges has decreased this year compared to the previous year.

Chief of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Ilam Toni Bardewa said that oranges have been planted in around 278.5 hectares of land in Ilam and only around 2,740 tonnes of oranges have been produced this year.

In the last fiscal year 2022/23, oranges were cultivated on 280 hectares of land and about 2,744 tonnes of oranges were produced. "Old plants, diseases, insects, lack of pruning and irrigation, and the effect of climate change have led to the destruction of several orange gardens in the district," said Bardewa.

"Now there are reports that oranges have started growing in the higher areas as well. It has been found that oranges have grown near the place where kiwi is cultivated," he said.

He said that the Centre has also started an orchard management strengthening programme to prevent oranges from being destroyed.

Lalitpur to restore Tiger Gate at Jawalakhel

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Dec. 31

Those travelling to Jawalakhel, Lalitpur may soon get to see two tigers on the streets.

Fret not, they are not real tigers but rather two statues that will be placed on either side of the main road leading to Jawalakhel, indicating that the Central Zoo lies nearby.

Chiri Babu Maharjan, the Mayor of Lalitpur Metropolitan City, announced on Saturday that he would install the statues soon, as a part of the city's plan to restore its 'Tiger Gate.'

"There used to be a tiger gate at Jawalakhel when we were children," he said, speaking at a programme organised by the National Trust for Nature Conservation (NTNC). "It was demolished for the coronation of King Birendra in 1975, but now, it will regain its existence."

The programme Maharjan spoke at was the 28th anniversary of the NTNC taking over the management of the menagerie.

On the occasion, he also informed that the specifications for a shuttle bus, which can be used to take persons with disabilities, had been finalised.

Maharjan, who was the chief guest of the function, also asked NTNC to pay attention to renovate and revitalise the large pond within its premises as it feeds two stone spouts, Iku Hiti and Hiku Hiti, of the city.

He also informed that the specifications for a shuttle bus, which can be used to take persons with disabilities, had been finalised.

Dr. Krishna Prasad Oli, chairperson of NTNC, also spoke at the event and informed of the many activities the zoo was carrying out in addition to caring for its animals. He shared that the zoo also functioned as a centre for animal rescue and breeding. He also highlighted the important work NTNC is doing in generating knowledge related to wildlife, climate change and people's livelihoods.

Dr. Sindhu Prasad Dhungana, director general of the Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation, and Indra Bhattarai, advisor of the Friends of Zoo (FOZ) Teacher's Committee, also presented their opinions and congratulated NTNC for its successful operation of the zoo.

Established as a private zoo in 1932 by the Rana Prime Minister Juddha Shumsher, the Central Zoo was taken over by the Government of Nepal after the political changes of 1950. It remained under the government's management until 1995 when it was handed over to the NTNC for 30 years.

Over 13,000 temporary houses built in Rukum West, Jajarkot



PHOTO: RAJU LAMICHHANE

A temporary house being built in Chaurjahari Municipality-5, Rukum West

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum Wests/Jajarkot, Dec. 31

Over 13,500 temporary houses have been built in Rukum West and Jajarkot districts with the grant given by the government to the earthquake victims.

An additional 9,341 temporary houses are under construction in Rukum West.

According to Hari Prasad Pant, Chief District Officer (CDO) of Rukum West, Rs. 592 million has been transferred from the District Disaster Fund to the Local Disaster Fund so far, but only 7,079 houses have been built with the grant amount.

According to the District Administration Office, 3,014 temporary shelters have been built in Athbiskot Municipality and 4,100 shelters are under construction. In Chaurjahari Municipality, construction of 265 temporary houses has been completed and 2,400 are under construction. Similarly, in Musikot Municipality, only 24 houses have been constructed so far and 48 are under construction.

Similarly, 3,042 temporary houses have been constructed in Sanibheri Rural Municipality so far and an additional 2,203 are being built. In Triveni Rural Municipality, 617 houses have been built and 550 houses are under construction. Similarly, 117 houses have been built in Banphikot Rural Municipality and 40 are under construction.

CDO Pant said that the amount of the first instalment for 23,608 beneficiaries from the District Disaster Fund has been sent to the disaster fund of respective local levels. The local level has deposited Rs. 493 million in the accounts of 19,717 beneficiaries.

In Chaurjahari Municipality, Rs. 150 million has been sent from the District Disaster Fund for 6,279 beneficiaries, while the municipality has collected Rs. 148.4 in the accounts of 5,938 beneficiaries. Rs. 175 million sent for 7,000 beneficiaries in Aathbiskot Municipality has been fully deposited in the accounts of the beneficiaries.

Likewise, 10,096 beneficiaries in Jajarkot received Rs. 252. 3 million grant to build temporary houses. Of the 20,344 who signed an agreement to receive the grant, only 10,096 got the first tranche of the grant. Of them, 6,598 built the temporary houses, according to the Information officer of District Administrative Office Jajarkot, Haris Chandra Sharma.

TIMBER SMUGGLERS TURN THEIR EYES TO RARE KHAIR SPECIES

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bardibas, Dec. 31

With authorities busy celebrating Christmas and New Year, timber smuggling has increased significantly. Recent activities have shown that the smugglers who were earlier smuggling Sakhu and Eucalyptus trees have recently turned their eyes to rare species of Khair trees.

The incident of Khair theft came to light after a forest patrol team recovered a large quantity of rare wood while searching the southern part of the forest area.

Based on the information given by an informant, the patrol under Krishna Kant Patel, Sub Division Chief and Avtar Lama, Maisthan Armed Forest Security Branch Chief seized 34 pieces of Khair trunks and five pieces of Sakhu from the mango orchard of Gaushala-8 of Kusumadi. The forest workers estimated that the recovered wood was cut only a few days ago.

It is not clear why the smugglers turned their eyes to Khair since it is not used in the construction of doors and furniture. Khair wood, which is a raw material for the production of medicine, is sold at a high price in the Indian industries.

According to the sources, there is also a high demand for it in the cross-border Indian market. As Indian industrialists also make cash payments, the eyes of smugglers have fallen on the Khair plants.

Patel informed that the Khair wood was stolen from the forest under the Sagarnath Forest Development Project and an investigation had started to arrest the smugglers.

The collected wood has been placed on the premises of the sub-division forest office at Maisthan and an investigation has begun.

Urban health centres in Sudur Pashchim Province non-functional



PHOTO: GOKARNA DAYAL

This building of the City Health Centre in Patan Municipality-8, Baitadi is not in use.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baitadi, Dec. 31

The building constructed for the operation of the urban health centre has been lying idle for three years due to the lack of medical equipment and medical personnel.

Due to the non-operation of services in the building of the urban health centre constructed at Dhari Jukepani in Patan Municipality-8, by the Sudur Pashchim Province government, pregnant women and sick children here are forced to go elsewhere to receive treatment.

"Although there are more than 300 households in Dhari Jukepani, local women, children and senior citizens are facing problems due to the lack of an urban health centre," complained Arjun Bista, a local. He said that the locals of Dhari-Jukepani, who live in the area where the urban health centre is constructed, were disappointed when the buildings remained in an abandoned situation.

Madan Mahara, Health Coordinator of Patan Municipality, said that although the provincial government had constructed a building in Dhari of Jukepani, service could not be started due to a lack of necessary medical equipment and health workers.

"Patan Municipality has no internal resources. There is a compulsion to run 21 health institutions in the city by hiring 60 contract employees. Rs. 185 million is spent annually to run the existing health institutions. There is no additional budget to run the urban health centre built by the provincial government," added Mahara.

Mahara informed that the provincial government did not coordinate with the local government while constructing the building of the urban health centre. "The building has fallen into disrepair due to the lack of health workers. Currently, it has been decided to operate a village clinic to provide vaccination services to the children once a month," said Mahara.

The building of another urban health centre built by the provincial government without coordination with the local level has also fallen into disrepair. The Health Branch of Patan Municipality informed that the services could not resume even in the newly constructed building of the Urban Health Centre in Patan Municipality-9, Kichar.

Yogesh Prasad Bhatt, Head of Health Office, Baitadi, said that four hospital buildings in Baitadi are lying idle due to a lack of coordination with the local level and federal government. He informed that the birthing centre was built by the provincial government at the cost of Rs. 2.5 million in Melauli Municipality-3, Lamalek, has been stalled due to non-operation of services.

"People of Baitadi often complain that they are not getting quality health care because of the poor performance of the contract health workers, said Bhatta

Tanahun teacher marks birthday by distributing woollen caps

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Dec. 31

A teacher in Tanahun celebrated his birthday by giving warm woollen caps to students. Gyanendra GC, a teacher working at Siddheshwari Secondary School of Byas Municipality-12, Kamalbari, celebrated his birthday by giving warm hats to the students to reduce unnecessary personal expenses.

Teacher GC gave woollen caps to 29 students studying in grades one to six.

GC is the secondary-level coordinator of the same school. GC said, "I did this kind of work intending to celebrate my birthday creatively. It is a pleasure to help the students, even if it is a small help."

Pham Bahadur Thapa, Chairman of the School Management Committee, said that since most of the students are from economically disadvantaged communities, providing them with warm caps would help them stay warm.

Narayan Prasad Adhikari, Headmaster of the school, said that helping the students by cutting unnecessary expenses on birthdays is an exemplary and commendable act.

International Competitive Bidding (ICB)

Invitation for bids for the supply of Chemical Fertilizer

Bid Identification No: STC/TN/D/2080/081/0007

1. Salt Trading Corporation Limited (STCL) invites sealed bids (hereinafter called the "Bid") from eligible bidders, for the procurement of the following chemical fertilizer (hereinafter called the "Goods"):

Chemical Fertilizer	N:P:K	Quantity in Metric Tons	Shipping tolerance
Diammonium Phosphate	18:46:00	25,000	+/- 2 percent

2. The following are the various timeline associated with the bid:

Tender details	Date	Time
First date of publication	1st January, 2024	-
Purchase of documents	All working days within 26th Jan, 2024	Within 1200 hours
Last date of submission of technical documents	All working days within 26th Jan, 2024	Within 1300 hours
Opening of technical bid documents	26th Jan, 2024,	At 1400 hours
Publication of technically qualified bidders	29th Jan, 2024	Within 1700 hours
Submission of financial bids	Within 2nd February, 2024	Within 1300 hours
Opening of financial bids	2nd February, 2024	At 1400 hours

3. The bid documents will comprise of two documents: (i) the technical bid document, and (ii) the financial bid documents. Disclosure of the price offer in the technical document will render the bidder as disqualified and the entire submission will be treated as non-responsive.
4. The technical and financial bids shall be opened at the time as specified in clause 2 on this notice at the office of STCL, Kalimati, Kathmandu, Nepal. The Financial bids must be valid for a period of 21 days counting from the day of the financial bid opening.
5. Bidder must quote the price in United States Dollars for the supply and delivery of above-mentioned **Chemical Fertilizer** on CIP warehouses delivery price on all of the following delivery points that are STCL Biratnagar, Birgunj and Bhairahawa warehouse. In case the bidder is an entity of Nepal, they must quote as per the prevailing law of Nepal and the directive(s) of Central Bank of Nepal (Nepal Rastra Bank). For evaluation purposes only, the rate of exchange will be the selling rates officially prescribed by Nepal Rastra Bank and prevailing on the date of opening of the tender. Payments will be done in United States Dollars.
6. Bid applicant must have prior experience of having supplied a minimum of the bid quantity of any chemical fertilizer to Nepal or any other countries during the last three years. The experience eligibility criteria are mentioned in clause 14, section B of the technical bid document.
7. The tender document can be obtained upon payment of a non-refundable fee of NRs 10,000.00 (Nepali Rupees ten thousand only) in cash or in form of bank receipt (bank account available upon request) for fee in favor of Salt Trading Corporation Limited, Kathmandu, Nepal.
8. Eligible bidders (principal) or their authorized representative can purchase the two signed and endorsed tender document on or before the time specified in clause 2 of this notice from STCL, Central Office, Kalimati, Kathmandu, Tel: +977-1-5371014, 5371208 and 5382022, e-mail: stcnepal1963@gmail.com by submitting a written application. In case of foreign bidder, the application letter must be in the local representative letterhead along with notarized copies of the following documents: (i) company/firm registration certificate of local representative, (ii) VAT/PAN certificate of local representative, (iii) recent tax clearance certificate of local representative, and (iv) authority letter issued by the eligible foreign bidder stating their intention to participate in the tender and also authorizing the said local representative company and name of assigned person to purchase the set of tender documents on their behalf. In case the bid is by a Nepali company, then the application letter must be issued by the said company duly stating that they themselves are the eligible bidders. In such a case, the Nepali bidder must submit notarized copies of their (i) company registration certificate, (ii) PAN/VAT registration certificate, and (iii) recent tax clearance certificate. In case foreign companies register a joint venture (JV) with Nepali company for the purpose of bidding in this contract, the said JV Company will have to submit all documents as applicable for Nepali bidders as well as a copy of the JV agreement. Eligible Bidders may be a private entity, government owned entity or any combination of them with a formal intent to enter into a contract.
9. After evaluation of the technical bids, a list of the qualified bidders name will be published in the company's website www.stcnepal.com and the bulletin board of STCL head office within the time as specified in clause 2 on this notice.
10. All interested bidders can attend the pre-bid meeting organized by STCL at its Kalimati, Kathmandu premises at 1400 hours of January 24th, 2024 to discuss confusions in the tender documents, if any. In case corrections are to be made as a result of the discussion at the said pre-bid meeting, the same will be incorporated in an amended tender document. The bidders are expected to examine all instructions, forms, terms and specifications in the bidding document. Failure to furnish all information required by the bidding documents or submission of a bid not substantially responsive to the bidding document in every respect shall be at the bidder's risk and will result in the rejection of its bid.
11. If the last date of purchasing, submission and opening of the bids (both technical and financial bid) falls on a Nepal Government holiday or a last minute holiday declaration by the Nepal Government, then the next working day for each subsequent phase of the tender bid shall be considered. In such a case, the bid validity and bid security validity shall be recognized with effect from the original bid submission deadline.
12. Purchased bid documents will be valid only for specified principal supplier.
13. The Purchaser (STCL) reserves the right to accept or reject the bid and to annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to the award of the contract without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Salt Trading Corporation Limited
Central Office, Business Department, Kalimati Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977 1 5371208/ 5371014
email: stcnepal1963@gmail.com | web: www.stcnepal.com

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Try to be like the turtle - at ease in your own shell.

-- Bill Copeland

EDITORIAL

Rebounding Tourism

Tourist arrival in Nepal in 2023 crossed the million mark, indicating the revival of visitor arrival and meeting the pre-COVID growth. In 2019, about 1.2 million foreign tourists had visited Nepal. The country was celebrating Visit Nepal Year 2020, and was on the path to achieve two million tourists arrival goal in a couple of years after that. But the COVID-19 pandemic shattered the dreams as severely damaged the sector, with Rs. 16 loss in every Rs. 100 business in tourism and hospitality front. Although Nepali tourism revival has fared better compared to its south Asian counterparts, the sector experienced a prolonged crisis.

This good news has raised hopes for the success of the government-announced tourism decade (2023–2033) and Visit Nepal Year 2025, and the tourism and hospitality sector is gearing up to welcome more tourists. Increased number of tourists also means better business for hotels, restaurants, airlines and travel and tour companies, as well as for handicraft items and Nepali indigenous products. It may create demand for such products in the international market as well.

However, the government and the private sector need to put additional efforts to maintain better infrastructure, information technology-based services, especially in the new tourist destinations. Better facilitation to the private sector is needed in developing hotels, adventure sports, cable cars and other amenities, while the government should focus on building good airports, roads and other public infrastructure, including public toilets. Projects like ski resort in Manang should be developed at the earliest in order to exhibit that Nepal has some world-class tourism facilities other than the Everest and Lumbini. Number of tourists from India has gone up significantly to 417,318 compared to 2019 arrivals, but there is a huge gap in the arrival of Chinese tourists as 60,160 tourists from the northern neighbour came to Nepal in 2023 which is about a third of the 2019 data.

Increasing facilities that can hold tourists for multiple days like trekking, mountaineering mountain flights, nature and wildlife safari and expanding them to the far-east and far-west should be the priority. Likewise, empowering the national flag carrier, Nepal Airlines Corporation, and opening new air route from the south for the successful operation of the international airports in Bhairahawa and Pokhara should be completed soon. Expediting negotiations with the European Union to remove Nepal from the air safety concern list should also be a priority so that Nepali airlines could conduct flight operations to various countries of Europe, which has long been a stable source market of tourists for Nepal. Likewise, Nepal can be a good destination for Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibitions (MICE) tourism as well as destination wedding.

Promotion of information technology in service delivery, both in public and private sectors, is also a fundamental need. Publicity of Nepali tourist destinations as well as creating new destinations and promoting them in international media with a focus on India, China and the Gulf countries could deliver better results. Meanwhile, a foreign tourist's average expenditure in Nepal is just US$ 48 a day which is quite low even compared to Bhutan, Bangladesh and India. Therefore, the government and the private sector should collaborate in developing the sector and expanding facilities in order to extend the stay of tourists and increase the per capita expense. A master plan should be created for the next decade for the holistic development of this sector.

Why We Get Frustrated

BISHALYA GAUTAM

People in my generation, who are in their early 20s, have studied our nation and its vast riches, rich history, and majestic mountains since a very young age. Everything that has ever been written or taught to us has been positive and has focused on the vast quantity of natural resources that we still have not used, as well as the few successes we have had.

Every young person has an illusion of grandeur and a false sense of hope since our educational system never really gave us an insight into the future our country was moving towards. Instead, it fed us the same wonderful past. Our generation is built on doubt and illusion. While it is impossible to deny a sense of patriotism or a commitment to doing good deeds for our nation, there are still too few outlets for inquisitive and innovative thinking. It appears that no one in a position of authority over a country is concerned about the number of young people who are leaving in quest of opportunities overseas to showcase their genuine abilities and pursue their passions.

Our political authorities are too preoccupied with placing the blame for the pervasive problems plaguing our country on individual citizens. In addition, there are still some common people who feel restricted by empty promises of the future. The same people show up to support the leaders who seem to be working together to obstruct any reforms that the country could try to implement. There are instances when someone has a really strong fundamental belief. They are unable to accept fresh information when it contradicts their preconceived notions. It would produce a very unsettling sensation known as cognitive dissonance. And because upholding the fundamental concept is so crucial, people will explain away, dismiss, or even deny everything that contradicts it.

With the way things are going in the nation at the moment, one would ask, is it the politicians whose moral fibre has been tarnished by money and self-serving ambition, or the people who vote to choose the responsible officials, rendering democracy ineffective?

Among the most intelligent people in the history of Western culture were fierce opponents of democracy. One of the most esteemed philosophers, Socrates, held somewhat divergent opinions about democracy. According to Plato, Socrates was discussing—more accurately, lecturing—the nature of the ideal state. He once asks Adeimantus, his associate, who he would prefer to have in charge of a naval voyage. Is that a random traveller or a skilled, knowledgeable, and seasoned captain? When the captain is chosen as the obvious choice, Socrates asks, "Why would we let just anybody try to manage the ship of state?" applying the metaphor to the state. He continues by suggesting that the perfect state would be a totalitarian one in which the leaders had decades of experience leading before assuming entire authority.

Even though distinguished philosophers have presented convincing arguments against democracy, we have also seen many examples of democracy's greatness in action, which further suggests that either we are unable to identify corrupt politicians from the past or we are never given the opportunity to vote correctly. I believe that the average citizen is only slightly satisfied with their situation. We cannot expect change unless a revolutionary fire burns deep within each disgruntled person. We are neither suffering enough to warrant a revolution nor content enough to happily accept this situation of no progress. Furthermore, we can look at the current situation in which the youth queue up to go abroad for lack of a viable opportunity to do something in their own motherland. Worst is when the youth have to fight to go abroad and get killed in the country.

Global Eyes On Five Elections



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

Mixed speculations grip the world order. At stake is the mantle of global leadership, hegemony and monopoly in agenda-setting. Credible history exposes hidden wickedness, nursed even by the high and mighty. Terrible as they are, hypocrites, among historians and record keepers, who juggle facts for narratives tailored to suit their ulterior motives. Massive changes were known to be in the making since the early phase of the new millennium. But only in recent years have the shifting sands of traditional world order been reluctantly and partially acknowledged by geo-strategists and analysts of world affairs that hog the space in the international media.

National priorities, primarily guided by security interests and economic benefits, are the elements of core focus for all countries. Who gains how much, under what conditions and with which ties are factors determined by military power, industrial base, market, geography, natural resources and individual vulnerabilities. As the noted political analyst Robert McChesney wrote nearly a decade and a half ago, there is a fundamental presupposition that guides US foreign policy, which was by and large accepted by "official sources" in both Republican and Democratic parties. It was almost never questioned in major US news media. "The notion was that the US is a benevolent force in the world keen on making the world a more just and democratic place."

Significant series

In a world with 193 member states at the United Nations, many countries will have parliamentary and presidential elections in 2024. This is something normal rather than an exception in the new millennium. Of special note to observers in this part of the globe is that three South Asian and two other superpower states—Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Russia and the US—face election exercises under interesting circumstances from next week to November.

Bangladesh braces for parliamentary polls on Sunday amid reports of intimidation and violence adversely affecting the democratically required atmosphere of free expression. The first among the four countries that go to national elections this year is Bangladesh. Its general election is scheduled for Sunday. Prime Minister Hasina Wajed's Awami League heads a grand alliance while the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) boycotts the "farce". This means Awami League's landslide victory is almost a certainty. In power since 2009, Prime Minister Hasina Wajed's Awami League is widely expected to be declared winner even as the opposition parties loudly protest against grievous harassment, imprisonment and misuse of state machinery. Wajed had a previous stint as the head of government from 1996 to 2001.

Former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia, serving a prison sentence on conviction of charges of corruption, continues to inspire BNP. In fact, thousands of BNP members have been thrown into jail. In office without a break since January 2009, Wajed has been prime minister for 15 years, in addition to her previous term from 1996 to 2001. Hers is a South Asian record.

On February 8, Pakistanis will vote a new parliament, in which Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf, Pakistan Muslim League (N) and Pakistan People's Party are seen as the major groups to have the largest presence. All three parties have had serious brushes with the military that toppled their elected prime ministers at different times since the 1990s. Overt or covert support from the army could prove crucial for the eventual shape of government.

In March, Russians vote for presidency, which even persistent critics of President Vladimir Putin seem to surrender to the highest probability of the incumbent retaining the top job for six more years. For credible opinion polls have consistently indicated Putin's popular approval rating at no less than 70 per cent—something his counterparts in Europe and the Americas envy.

> The election campaigns and the eventual results this year in Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Russia and the US generate keen and close attention among political observers and analysts across the world.

That would mean Putin remaining in power for 30 years without a break for all practical purposes. Boris Yeltsin, who supervised the collapse of Soviet Union, the world's first communist state, was widely appreciated in the capitalist West for the role played. He abruptly stepped down on December 31, 1999, making way for his vice-president to take over the vacated post. Yeltsin made a pact with Vice-President Putin to step down a year before his second term was to complete in exchange for immunity to him and his family from any investigation.

Shortly after donning the hat of the executive head, Putin issued immunity rights to his predecessor and consolidated his power base in the ensuring 12 months to the extent that he won the next two terms of four years each. Since constitutional ceiling prevented him from a third consecutive tenure, he backed his close ally Dmitry Medvedev's to the high office and chose to serve as prime minister from 2008 to 2012. Four years later, Putin returned contested and won the presidential contest and later amended the Constitution enabling him to contest not only in 2024 but also in 2030.

In the November 20 election, the US might witness a rematch between former President Donald Trump and incumbent President Joe Biden. Surveys suggest Trump to have a runaway lead over the few candidates seeking Republican Party ticket, with a lead margin of more than 50 per cent against the nearest aspirant. In the Democratic camp, will Biden summon adequate stamina for the marathon campaign to the November 20 contest or will he be persuaded to step aside for a younger candidate?

India's parliamentary polls, according to analyses in some of the leading Western news media, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is most likely to steer his Bharatiya Janata Party to a third consecutive victory in April-May.

Awaited record

The hattrick would match what the Congress led by founder Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru achieved after independence in 1947. It would mean Modi leaving office in a blaze of glory both at national and international levels, given the opportunities he is heaped upon. He pledges his party to lift India to the group of developed nations by the year 2047, which marks the centenary of the country's Independence Day.

In a bid to offer the prime minister a tougher fight, the Congress and 27 other opposition parties have formed a coalition grouping whose chief objective is "oust BJP". The tie-up has named itself as Indian National Developmental Inclusion Alliance (INDIA). The election campaigns and the eventual results this year in Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Russia and the US generate keen and close attention among political observers and analysts across the world, given that the five also account for 27 per cent of world's total population.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Address Concerns Of Youths



Ballav Dahal

With insufficient jobs and other livelihood opportunities within the country, Nepali jobseekers, especially youths, have kept losing their hopes. So, they are forced to go abroad in pursuit of better life prospects. But this is also not easy. A lot of youths are often found fallen prey to mafias. Such vulnerable lots time and again go through difficulties in the course of getting to job destinations. This is because human traffickers mostly use illegal means while sending people from one country to another. Many of such victims have got swindled while some others have lost their lives in foreign countries. There have been instances where Nepali trafficking victims have languished in foreign jails. Despite frequent disclosure of horrible stories of the victims of trafficking, other poor and deprived youths easily fall into the trap of swindlers as they want to go overseas to do something for themselves and their family.

Unfortunate incident

The Korean job market is considered more lucrative than others in terms of salary, job security and other facilities. This is the reason behind a growing interest among youths to get to Korea. Employers in the Republic of Korea (RoK) have also loved to hire Nepali workers because the latter are regarded as more honest and hardworking than others. But, an unfortunate incident took place in Balkumari of Lalitpur on Friday when two youths lost their lives in a clash with police. A lot of disappointed youths were taking to the streets at Balkumari to protest the alleged obstacles to their participation in Employment Permit System (EPS) examination. The protesters demanded that those who failed in shipbuilding job selection process be allowed to appear in manufacturing sector job selection exams.

But things turned horrible when the irate demonstrators set a vehicle of Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala on fire. To stop the protesters from causing further damage, the police personnel on duty resorted to firing, killing the two and injuring several others. That incident has disappointed youths further as their demand was genuine. However, having realised the mistake, the government has formed an investigation panel to find out how such a disastrous situation had emerged. If the concerned authorities had handled the situation tactfully, such an adversity would have been prevented.

A host of Nepali youths are suspected to have stuck in Russia and Ukraine as well. Some of them have already been killed in the war while few are now under the control of Ukraine. After the breakout of the Russia-Ukraine war in February 2022, the Russian government adopted the policy of recruiting Nepalis and other foreign nationals in its military service. Russia also announced to issue its citizenship to such persons for their contribution to it in a critical time. With the announcement of this policy, manpower agencies and other traffickers seem to have cashed in on it by sending Nepalis to Russia via India, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and other countries.

Although the families of those trapped in foreign nations have requested the government to make every possible effort for their rescue, no solid step appear to have so far been taken in this connection. Neither the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) possesses the information about the number of Nepalis serving the Russian army nor has it been successful in bringing the dead home. However, the police have lately arrested some manpower agents allegedly involved in sending Nepali youths to Russia for joining the military service. Had the National Investigation Department and other related bodies played a proactive role in preventing human trafficking, the youths should not have died.

> Since youths' contribution to the task of nation building is very important, it is necessary for all the three-tier governments to create a congenial environment for such an energetic section of the society to retain within the country.

Rising incidences of corruption and other political anomalies have also created a sense of dissatisfaction among youths. Despite the government's measures to crack down on corruption, the country has witnessed numerous fiscal and other irregularities one after another. The controversial purchase and sale of shares of Ncell is a fresh example of corruption. The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) under the House of Representatives has recently directed the government to halt this. The government has also formed a committee to investigate the issue. The committee must bring the fact to light and the government needs to stop the purchase and sale of this private telecommunication company's shares as there is something wrong with it. Even Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', while speaking at a meeting of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee recently, said that the transaction of shares was unnatural.

Wrong tendency

Likewise, unwanted political interferences in universities have crippled the higher education sector. There is a wrong tendency of sharing top university positions among political parties. This practice has caused huge damage to these institutions. Instead of imparting quality education, the universities appear to have turned out to be venues for political ploys. Although there are many universities and colleges across the nation, the number of students getting enrollment there is reported to be falling sharply. Most private colleges in Nepal seem to have named after reputed foreign colleges to attract more students. But there has been a growing trend among students to go abroad for higher studies because of commercialisation of education and unnecessary political interventions in knowledge imparting institutions.

Since youths' contribution to the task of nation building is very important, it is necessary for all the three-tier governments to create a congenial environment for such an energetic section of the society to retain within the country. All concerns of youths must be addressed so as to encourage them to join hands with governments for taking the country to the path of development and prosperity.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 1, 1974

Nepal's Foreign Policy Lauded

Kathmandu, Dec. 31: The visiting Deputy Premier of Tajik SSR Mrs. Makhfirang Karimova has lauded the foreign policy of Nepal and her attitude towards world peace, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.

Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Invest in Tourism Infrastructure



I am writing this with regard to news report titled "*More than one million tourists arrive in 2023*" published in this daily on Dec. 31. According to the report, the total number of tourists who visited Nepal via air in the year 2023 is at least 1,008,614, meeting the government's goal of bringing in one million foreign tourists and nearing the pre-pandemic level.

This is a testament to the fact that the country's economy is showing signs of recovery, and even more good things are on the horizon. With snow-capped majestic mountains, picturesque landscape and villages, fascinating culture and intriguing cultural heritages, open and progressive people and many more, Nepal's potential in tourism is vast. More tourists will land in this beautiful country if more investment is poured in infrastructure development and in making city environment free of dust and pollution. Though many parts of Kathmandu have become visibly dust-free, more needs to be done.

Kapil Basyal
Texas, USA

TAILPIECE

A young man asked an old rich man how he made his money.

The old guy fingered his worsted wool vest and said, "Well, son, it was 1932. The depth of the Great Depression. I was down to my last nickel.

"I invested that nickel in an apple. I spent the entire day polishing the apple and, at the end of the day, I sold the apple for ten cents.

"The next morning, I invested those ten cents in two apples. I spent the entire day polishing them and sold them at 5:00 pm for 20 cents. I continued this system for a month, by the end of which I'd accumulated a fortune of $1.37."

"And that's how you built an empire?" the boy asked.

"Heavens, no!" the man replied. "Then my wife's father died and left us two million dollars."

Russia launches fresh drone strikes on Ukraine



Photo: AP

In this photo taken from video released by Russia Emergency Situations Ministry telegram channel on Saturday, Dec. 30, 2023, Firefighters extinguish burning cars after shelling in Belgorod, Russia.

AP
Ukraine, Dec. 31

Russia launched a fresh drone assault on Ukraine on Saturday night, after promising that strikes on the Russian border city of Belgorod earlier in the day "would not go unpunished".

The Ukrainian Air Force said Sunday that it had shot down 21 of 49 drones launched by Russian forces overnight.

Twenty-eight people were wounded in an attack on the eastern city of Kharkiv, regional Gov. Oleh Syniehubov said Sunday.

A central hotel, apartment buildings, kindergarten, shops and administrative buildings sustained damage, according to the regional prosecutor's office.

In the Kyiv region that surrounds the capital, a Russian drone attack caused a fire to break out at a critical infrastructure facility, local officials said.

They did not identify the facility further.

The Russian attacks came after shelling in the center of the Russian border city of Belgorod Saturday killed 24 people, including three children.

A further 108 people were wounded in the strike, regional governor Vyacheslav Gladkov said Sunday, making it one of the deadliest attacks on Russian soil since the start of Moscow's invasion of Ukraine 22 months ago.

Russian authorities accused Kyiv of carrying out the attack, which took place the day after an 18-hour Russian aerial bombardment across Ukraine killed at least 41 civilians.

Russia's Defense Ministry said it identified the ammunition used in the strike as Czech-made Vampire rockets and Olkha missiles fitted with cluster-munition warheads. It provided no additional information, and The Associated Press was unable to verify its claims.

"This crime will not go unpunished," the ministry said in a statement on social media.

In an emergency meeting at the U.N. Security Council demanded by Russia Saturday night, envoy Vasily Nebenzya accused Kyiv of a "terrorist attack." In comments carried by Russian state media, Nebenzya claimed Ukraine had launched "a deliberate act of terrorism directed against civilians."

Gaza war will continue: Netanyahu



AFP
Isreal, Dec. 31

Israeli Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu said Saturday that Israel's war with Palestinian militant group Hamas will "continue for many months until Hamas is eliminated and the hostages are returned". Netanyahu was speaking at a news conference hours after the health ministry in Gaza said more than 21,670 people have been killed and more than 56,160 injured from Israeli strikes in the enclave since October 7, the date of the deadly Hamas-led attack on Israel.

Israeli Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu on Saturday renewed his pledge to eliminate the Palestinian militant group Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

Vowing to bring home all Israelis still held hostage in Gaza, Netanyahu said the Israeli military was involved in a "complex fight" and needed time to achieve its goals.

"The war will continue for many months until Hamas is eliminated and the hostages are returned," Netanyahu told a news conference.

"We will guarantee that Gaza will no longer pose a threat to Israel," he said, adding that around 8,000 militants had already been killed in Israel's military campaign in the Palestinian territory.

"Step by step we are depriving Hamas of their capabilities ... We will also eliminate the leaders."

US news outlet Axios and Israeli website Ynet, both citing unnamed Israeli officials, reported that Qatari mediators had told Israel that Hamas was prepared to resume talks on new hostage releases in exchange for a ceasefire in the war.

When asked if a new deal for hostage releases was being negotiated, Netanyahu said Hamas had been "giving all kinds of ultimatums that we didn't accept".

"We are seeing a certain shift (but) I don't want to create an expectation," he said without elaborating.

A Hamas delegation was in Cairo on Friday to discuss an Egyptian plan for renewable ceasefires, a staggered release of hostages for Palestinian prisoners and ultimately an end to the war, sources close to Hamas said.

South Africa's parliament a symbol of country's woes

AFP
Cape Town, Dec. 31

Charred beams and broken tiles still poke out from the gutted roof of South Africa's parliament in Cape Town two years after it was engulfed by a devastating fire.

For many, the arson attack and the scars, partially hidden behind the monumental white and red facade, symbolise the country's ills as it goes into an election year.

Reconstruction has been slow and the 400 National Assembly lawmakers have been forced into a smaller hall in the city that can only handle 170 of them.

A probe into the arson by a man who has been declared unfit to stand trial, found guards sleeping on the job amongst a litany of security lapses.

The fire and its aftermath highlight a "failing state" that cannot maintain basic services, ignores safety standards and where planning is "in tatters", said political analyst Sandile Swana.

"This all creates an atmosphere of precarity and general unsafeness," he told AFP.

The main reconstruction at the iconic site will begin in January and take two years to complete -- in line with "the timeframes that were announced", according to parliament spokesman Moloto Mothapo.

It has taken two years to secure funding and permits, remove rubble and artefacts in the gutted building and lay the groundwork, he added.

With 2024 marking three decades since the advent of democracy, the starting date is itself steeped in symbolism. Mothapo told AFP this would help ensure that parliament "is restored and made even better.

"The institution is not just bricks and mortar. It carries the hopes and aspirations, and the future of the great majority of South Africans."

"We can all agree this has been a frustratingly long process," Siviwe Gwarube, chief whip for the main opposition Democratic Alliance (DA) told a parliamentary committee this year.

It took firefighters more than 48 hours to control the flames when the building was set ablaze on January 2, 2022.

Though no one was killed, the fire caused $120 million of damage and wrecked a chamber that was the scene of historic moments, including President FW de Klerk announcing the release of Nelson Mandela after 27 years in prison in 1990.

Mothapo said the revamped building will have "added elements of modernity" and house a larger chamber able to accommodate a joint sitting of the two parliament houses.

In the meantime the MPs not lucky enough to be given seats and the public now have to watch debates online. That hurts transparency, said Brett Herron, of the small opposition GOOD party.

NKorea's Kim vows to launch three more spy satellites

AP
South Korea, Dec. 31

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un vowed to launch three additional military spy satellites, produce more nuclear materials and introduce modern attack drones in 2024, as he called for "overwhelming" war readiness to cope with U.S.-led confrontational moves, state media reported Sunday.

Kim's comments, made during a key ruling Workers' Party meeting to set state goals for next year, suggest he'll intensify a run of weapons tests ahead of the U.S. presidential elections in November. Observers say Kim believes a boosted nuclear capability would give him another chance to launch high-stakes summit diplomacy with the U.S. to win sanctions relief if former President Donald Trump returns to the White House.

During the five-day meeting that ended Saturday, Kim said anti-North Korea moves by the United States and its followers have been unprecedented this year, pushing the Korean Peninsula to the brink of a nuclear war, according to the official Korean Central News Agency. Kim cited the expansion of U.S.-South Korean military exercises and the temporary deployment of powerful U.S. military assets such as bombers and a nuclear-armed submarine in South Korea — steps the allies have taken in response to the North's weapons testing spree since last year.



Photo: AP

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, center, attends a year-end plenary meeting of the ruling Workers' Party, which was held between Dec. 26, and Dec. 30, 2023, in Pyongyang, North Korea.

"The grave situation requires us to accelerate works to acquire overwhelming war response capabilities and thorough and perfect military readiness to suppress any types of provocations by the enemies at a stroke," Kim said, according to KCNA.

Kim set forth plans to launch three more military spy satellites next year in addition to the country's first reconnaissance satellite launched in November. He underscored the need to establish "a reliable foundation" to build more nuclear weapons, an apparent reference to facilities to produce fissile materials like weapons-grade plutonium and highly enriched uranium.

Kim also ordered authorities to enhance submarine capabilities and develop various types of modern unmanned combat equipment such as armed drones, according to KCNA.

"Pyongyang might be waiting out the U.S. presidential election to see what its provocations can buy it with the next administration," said Leif-Eric Easley, a professor at Ewha University in Seoul.

PRISM

Lost wallet found after 65 years

Atlanta: Workers remodeling an Atlanta movie theater found something surprising behind a wall: a wallet that had been lost by a patron 65 years earlier. A contractor found the old wallet behind a wall at the Plaza Theater and turned it over to the cinema's owner, Chris Escobar.

Escobar said the area where the wallet was found was likely a former lost and found area in a manager's office that had long-since been hidden by renovations.

"It was a portal back in time," Escobar told CNN of the wallet. "And then realizing that this has been missing from this family of real people who lived in this neighborhood for 65 years, imagine if we could find them."

Escobar did some research online and discovered the wallet's owner, Floy Culbreth, died at age 87 in 2005. But he was able to contact her daughter, Thea Culbreth Chamberlain, 71.

Man puts on 10 underpants in 13 seconds

Australia: An Australian man said it took six months of training to break an unusual world record: the fastest time to put on 10 pairs of underpants.

Nicholas Manning of Brisbane said he always wanted to break a Guinness World Record, and he eventually settled on attempting the underpants donning title. Manning said it took him six months of practice to develop and refine his technique.

He successfully broke the record with a time of 13.03 seconds.

(AP)

After wars, bots and Barbie, world rings in 2024

AFP
Sydney, Dec. 31

Jubilant crowds will bid farewell to the hottest year on record Sunday, closing a turbulent 12 months marked by clever chatbots, climate crises and wrenching wars in Gaza and Ukraine.

The world's population -- now over eight billion -- will see out the old and usher in the new, with many hoping to shake the weight of high living costs and global tumult.

In Sydney, the self-proclaimed "New Year's capital of the world", more than a million partygoers are expected to pack the city's foreshore.

Even before nightfall, tens of thousands of people gathered at vantage points around the city's iconic Harbour Bridge, defying uncharacteristically dank weather.

At midnight, eight tonnes of fireworks will light the fuse on 2024, a year that will bring elections concerning half the world's population and a summer Olympiad celebrated in Paris.



Photo: AFP

A New Year's Eve rehearsal in Times Square in New York on December 29, 2023

The last 12 months brought "Barbiegeddon" at the box office, a proliferation of human-seeming artificial intelligence tools and a world-first whole-eye transplant.

India outgrew China as the world's most populous country, and then became the first nation to land a rocket on the dark side of the moon.

It was also the hottest year since records began in 1880, with a spate of climate-fuelled disasters striking from Australia to the Horn of Africa and the Amazon basin.

Fans bade adieu to "Queen of Rock 'n' Roll" Tina Turner, "Friends" actor Matthew Perry, hell-raising Anglo-Irish songsmith Shane MacGowan and master dystopian novelist Cormac McCarthy.

Perhaps more than anything, 2023 will be remembered for war in the Middle East -- for Hamas's brutal October 7 raids on southern Israel and Israel's ferocious reprisals.

The United Nations estimates that almost two million Gazans have been displaced since Israel's siege began -- about 85 percent of the peacetime population.

With once-bustling Gaza City neighbourhoods reduced to rubble, there were few places left to mark the new year -- and fewer loved ones to celebrate with.

"It was a black year full of tragedies," said Abed Akkawi, who fled the city with his wife and three children.

The 37-year-old, now living in a UN shelter in Rafah, southern Gaza, said the war had obliterated his house and killed his brother.

But still, he clings to modest hopes for 2024.

"God willing this war will end, the new year will be a better one, and we will be able to return to our homes and rebuild them, or even live in a tent on the rubble," he told AFP.

In Ukraine, where Russia's invasion grinds towards its second anniversary, there was also hope, and defiance in the face of a renewed assault from Moscow.

"Victory! We are waiting for it and believe that Ukraine will win," said Tetiana Shostka as air raid sirens blared in Kyiv.

"We will have everything we want if Ukraine is free, without Russia," the 42-year-old added.

Some in Vladimir Putin's Russia are also weary of the conflict.

"In the new year I would like the war to end, a new president, and a return to normal life," said 55-year-old theatre decorator and Moscow resident Zoya Karpova.

Putin is already his country's longest-tenured leader since Joseph Stalin and his name will again be on the ballot paper when Russians vote in March.

Few expect the vote to be fully free or fair, or for the former KGB man to return to the shadows.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1600 – Scotland recognises January 1 as the start of the year, instead of March 25.
1502 – The present-day location of Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, is first explored by the Portuguese.
1651 – Charles II is crowned King of Scotland at Scone Palace.
1808 – The United States bans the importation of slaves.
1863 – American Civil War: The Emancipation Proclamation takes effect in Confederate territory.
1877 – Queen Victoria of the United Kingdom is proclaimed Empress of India.
1885 – Twenty-five nations adopt Sandford Fleming's proposal for standard time (and also, time zones).
1912 – The Republic of China is established.
1942 – The Declaration by United Nations is signed by twenty-six nations.
1976 – A bomb explodes on board Middle East Airlines Flight 438 over Qaisumah, Saudi Arabia, killing all 81 people on board.

BRIEFS

One dies in truck-bike collision

Waling:
A motorcycle rider was killed when a bus and a truck collided on Saturday night at Bajhyadi in Galyang Municipality-1 of Syangja along the Siddhartha Highway.

In the accident, motorcycle rider Deepak Thapa, 43, of Galyang-2, died. He succumbed to injuries while undergoing treatment at Garhaun Primary Hospital, Waling, according to police Inspector Pawal Singh Lama of the District Police Office.

The motorcycle with registration number Lu 38 Pa 2445 was heading towards Galyang from Butwal and the truck (Lu 1 Kha 5143) was heading towards Butwal from Waling. Police have impounded the truck and detained its driver.

Woman killed in attack
Damak: An elderly woman was killed in Damak of Jhapa on Saturday afternoon.

According to the District Police Office, 60-year-old Indra Kumari BK was attacked by her husband Dhan Bahadur of Damak Municipality-2 of the district over a minor dispute.

Dhan Bahadur attacked Indra Kumari with Khukuri, DSP Khagendra Rijal said. Following the incident, he was immediately arrested along with the weapon and was taken to the District Police Office for further action.

US FORCES SHOOT DOWN BALLISTIC MISSILES IN THE RED SEA

AP
Berut, Dec. 31

The U.S. military said Sunday it shot down two anti-ship ballistic missiles fired toward a container ship by Yemen's Houthi rebels in the Red Sea. Hours later, four boats tried to attack the same ship, but U.S. forces opened fire, killing several of the armed crews, the U.S. Central Command said. No one was injured on the ship.

The Singapore-flagged MAERSK HANZGHOU reported they had already been hit by a missile Saturday night while transiting the Southern Red Sea and requested assistance, CENTCOM said in a statement. The USS GRAVELY and USS LABOON responded to the call for help, and the Denmark-owned vessel was reportedly seaworthy and no injuries were noted, the statement added.

"This is the 23rd illegal attack by the Houthis on international shipping since Nov. 19," CENTCOM said.

In another statement, CENTCOM said the same ship issued an additional distress call about a second attack "by four Iranian-backed Houthi small boats." The attackers fired small arms weapons at the MAERSK HANZGHOU, getting to within 20 meters (about 65 feet) of the vessel, and attempted to it, CENTCOM said.

A contract-embarked security team on the ship returned fire, the central command said. U.S. helicopters from the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower aircraft carrier and GRAVELY responded to the distress call and while issuing verbal warnings to the attackers, the small boat crews opened fire on the helicopters using small arms, the statement said.



PHOTO: RSS

People are compelled to use a makeshift bridge to cross Kamala River joining Dhanusha and Siraha along Postal Highway as the concrete bridge has still been under construction for past 13 years.

Campaign held for youth friendly local governance

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

The stakeholders have expressed solidarity and interest in the acceleration of the Youth Friendly Local Governance (YFLG) campaign as a basis for ensuring the rights endowed to the youths during the discussion of the YFLG campaign.

Review, reflection, and closing of the second phase of the YFLG programme was conducted on Saturday.

According to Tilottam Poudel, President of Jagriti Child and Youth Concern Nepal (JCYCN) and Executive member of National Youth Council (NYC), 52 representatives from various sectors like youth clubs, LGBTIQ advocates, adolescent networks, environmental activists, development partners, feminists, Civil Society and media personnel participated in the campaign.

Jagriti Child and Youth Corner Nepal (JCYCN) in collaboration with Nepal National Youth Council, and UNDP Nepal has been conducting the YFLG program since last year.

The programme was initiated as a pilot intervention in the selected seven local governments, one from each of the seven provinces, and was expanded to an additional seven local governments in 2023, said Tilottam Paudel,

The meeting was chaired by Dinesh Ghimire, Administrative Chief of the National Youth Council (NYC).

Bishnu Khatri, Training Coordinator of YFLG, stressed deeper engagement of stakeholders, mobilisation of YFLG trainers, documentation of initiatives, and institutionalised participation of youth as key strategies for the success of the campaign.

A comprehensive overview of the YFLG campaign, including its history, progress, and future trajectory, was presented by Sumikshya Khadka, the Team Leader of the YFLG programme at JCYCN.

Dinesh Ghimire said that NYC has been prioritising the YFLG campaign by offering conditional grants to one local government each in all 77 districts, and all seven provinces, and initiating specialised programmes like One School: One Entrepreneur.

Narayan Krishna Shrestha, Deputy Chief of the Plan International, and Binod Shahi member of the National Youth Council highlighted the pressing challenges faced by youths, including brain drain, unemployment, and drug abuse.

They stressed the importance of addressing these issues by increasing investment in youths and implementing the YFLG agenda as a sustainable campaign.

Suran Maharjan, Country Coordinator of United Nations Volunteers (UNV) Nepal, provided information on the youth opportunities created by UNV and encouraged the youths to make the best out of such opportunities.

Sabnam Sunar, a peer educator within the Girls' Empowerment Project of JCYCN, highlighted the significance of employing effective strategies, creating entrepreneurial avenues, and ensuring accessible resources to encourage youth engagement, investment, and overall development in the country.

As per the Nepal Census, 2021, the population of youth (between the age group of 16-40) is 42.56 per cent, which is an increase by 2.21 per cent compared to the 2011 census.

This demographic shift marks a significant moment in Nepal's history, presenting a 'population dividend' or 'youth bulge'—a scenario where the youth form the most substantial portion of the country's population.

Putin lauds Russian unity in his New Year's address

AP
Moscow, Dec. 31

Russian President Vladimir Putin praised Russia's "united society" in his prerecorded New Year's address to the nation, the country's state news agencies reported Sunday.

Putin addressed Russians in a video that ran under four minutes long, significantly shorter than the New Year's speech he gave last year, according to state news agency RIA Novosti. Millions of people were expected to watch the new address when it airs on TV as each Russian time zone region counts down the final minutes of 2023 on Sunday.

The first to see it were residents of the Kamchatka Peninsula and the Chukotka region in Russia's Far East, some nine hours ahead of Moscow.

Returning to tradition after speaking flanked by soldiers last year, Putin delivered his address to the nation against the backdrop of a snowy Kremlin. In remarks carried by RIA Novosti, he described 2023 as a year marked by high levels of unity in Russian society.

"What united us and unites us is the fate of the Fatherland, a deep understanding of the highest significance of the historical stage through which Russia is passing," the president said. He also lauded Russian citizens' "solidarity, mercy and fortitude."

QR scan system introduced in Kalikot to file police complaints

BY PREMRAJ SIMKHADA
Kalikot, Dec. 31

The hassle of visiting the police office to lodge any complaint has now come to an end at least in Kalikot district.

The District Police Office, Kalikot, has arranged a system through which one can lodge complaints and provide any information to the police using a QR Code Scan. The compulsion to reach the police office was solved after the DPO arranged a system for the citizens to file complaints digitally.

"QR code scanner signals have been pasted in various areas of the district headquarters, Manma so that locals could lodge complaints to police without visiting the police office," said Arjun KC, Superintendent of Police and Chief of the District Police Office.

KC said that the quick response code was made public to ensure easy and accessible services to all.

He said that the QR code would be used to collect complaints, and problems and get constructive suggestions from the citizens.

"The name of the persons who register s against any wrongdoers will be kept confidential," said SP K.C.

Locals will be able to file complaints through technology from anywhere for problems and weaknesses seen in peace and security, as well as for effective service delivery, he said.

But the possibility of using the service by the citizens of Kalikot, who do not even have a mobile phone and the mobile phones, even if they have, do not function well due to weak towers, looks low.

Nabin Kumar Shahi of Tilagufa Municipality-6 of Jubitha, said that citizens from the remote areas who even did not know how to use mobile phones could not benefit from the service.

The system is fine for the citizens of cities like Kathmandu, Butwal and Biratnagar, but in the Himalayan districts like Kalikot, the citizens could not apply the QR code correctly.

Afghan people make grueling journeys to survive

AP
Torkham (Afghanistan), Dec. 31

The barren desert plain among the mountains of eastern Afghanistan is filled with hundreds of thousands of people.

Some live in tents. Others live out in the open, among the piles of the few belongings they managed to take as they were forced from neighboring Pakistan.

The sprawling camp of people returning to Afghanistan through the Torkham border crossing is the latest facet of Afghans' long, painful search for a stable home.

More than 40 years of war, violence and poverty in Afghanistan have created one of the world's most uprooted populations. Some 6 million Afghans are refugees outside the country. Another 3.5 million people are displaced within the country of 40 million, driven from their homes by war, earthquakes, drought or resources that are being depleted.

Over the course of months, an Associated Press photographer traveled across Afghanistan from its eastern border with Pakistan to its western border with Iran, getting to know displaced people and returned refuges and capturing their images.

Afghanistan is already a poor country, especially after the economic collapse that followed the takeover by the Taliban two years ago. More than 28 million people — two-thirds of the population — rely on international aid to survive.

The displaced are among the poorest of the poor. Many live in camps around the country, unable to afford enough food or firewood for heat in the winter. Women and children often turn to begging. Others marry off their young daughters to families willing to pay them money.

In an camp for internally displaced people outside Kabul, it was 15-year-old Shamila's wedding day. She stood in a bright-red dress among the family's women, who congratulated her. But the girl was miserable.

"I have no choice. If I don't accept, my family will be hurt," said Shamila, whose father did not give the family's name because he feared being identified by the Taliban. Her groom's family is giving her father money to pay off the debts he's had to take on to support his wife and children.

"I wanted to study and work, I should have gone to school," Shamila said. "I have to forget all my dreams … so at least I can help my father and my family a little and maybe I can take the burden off their shoulders."

Pakistan's decision earlier this year to deport Afghans who entered illegally struck hard. Many Afghans have lived for decades in Pakistan, driven there by successive wars at home. When the order was announced, hundreds of thousands feared arrest and fled back to Afghanistan. Often Pakistani authorities prevented them from taking anything with them, they say.

Lhosar oldest...

Fiscal Commission members, Nepal Federation of Indigenous Nationalities and others were present.

Meanwhile, Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung has said that national unity will be strengthened only by showing respect to all religions, cultures and costumes.

Speaking at the Tamu Lhosar greeting exchange programme organised by Tamu Hyaul Choja Dhi National Council on Sunday, Minister Gurung, who is also vice president of the Nepali Congress, said "The followers of one culture must respect the followers of other cultures and followers of one faith must show respect to the followers of other faiths, only then the country will be stronger."

Religious and cultural tolerance will be possible when we respect each other's cultures and traditions, he said.

PM instructs to...

exams for EPS, a test of proficiency in the Korean language that is the first step to getting a job in South Korea. The youth set the vehicle of Prakash Jwala, Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, on fire.

Earlier on Saturday, the government suspended the police chief and chief district officer of Lalitpur, and chief of EPS Korea Branch until the investigations into the case are over.

NC to pick...

on youth, industry and business for employment generation taking note of development trends on the country's economic, social and political fronts.

The party urged the government to form a high-level probe committee on the recent Balkumari incident, provide employment in the country to minimum one family member of the victims killed in the Balkumari incident, provide appropriate compensation to the families of the deceased, free treatment of the injured and adopt necessary special policy to avert such incidents in future.

It also asked the government to resolve the problems seen in the cooperative sector as soon as possible by implementing the report of High Level Mechanism.

The meeting also endorsed the date of the Mahasamiti meeting for February 19-22, 2024 as decided by the party Central Work Execution Committee. It also decided to conclude the Congress in Community campaign by deploying central representatives from January 21 to February 5, extend the tenure of six sister organizations' ad-hoc committees to hold their general convention within six months.

Likewise, the meeting decided to constitute a central mechanism of the party to make the work of representatives inducted by the NC effective by proper coordinating, celebrate National Unity and Reconciliation Day on Monday and underscore speedy reconstruction in Jajarkot.

More Rohingya refugees arrive in Indonesia

AP
Medan (Indonesia), Dec. 31

Nearly 150 Rohingya refugees, mostly hungry and weak women and children, have reached a beach in Indonesia's North Sumatra province after weeks at sea, officials said Sunday.

The group of 53 men, 39 women and 55 children arrived on Karang Gadih beach in Langkat district late Saturday, said the village head, Muhammad Amiruddin. A rickety, leaky wooden boat that brought them from Bangladesh was moored on a lighthouse island not far from the village, he said.

Five among the refugees were sick after the long journey and residents gave them food and water while they waited for instructions from immigration and local officials to decide where to take them.

Residents do not want the refugees in their communities, however, and last week many protested the recent Rohingya arrivals.

"We helped them as they look very weak from hunger and dehydration," Amiruddin said. "But many residents cannot accept them to live in our village because they will only bring problems later."



PHOTO: AP

Ethnic Rohingya women rest under a tent after landing on a beach in Kuala Besar, North Sumatra, Indonesia, Sunday, Dec 31.

He said that one of the refugees told authorities that they sailed from the Cox Bazar refugee camp in Bangladesh to Indonesia and became stranded on a lighthouse island.

About 740,000 Rohingya were resettled in Bangladesh after fleeing their homes in Myanmar to escape a brutal counterinsurgency campaign by security forces. But the camps in Bangladesh are squalid, with surging gang violence and rampant hunger, leading many to flee again.

A mob of Indonesian students on Wednesday attacked the basement of a local community hall in Banda Aceh, the capital of Aceh province, where 137 Rohingya were taking shelter. The incident drew an outcry from human rights group and the U.N. refugee agency, which said the attack left the refugees shocked and traumatized.

Indonesia's navy said Thursday that it forcibly pushed a boat packed with refugees back to international waters after it approached the shores of Aceh province.

It's unclear whether the refugees who arrived late Saturday in neighboring North Sumatra province were from the same boat that was pushed away by the navy.

Indonesia has appealed to the international community for help and intensified patrols of its waters due to a sharp rise in Rohingya refugees leaving overcrowded camps in Bangladesh since November. Over 1,500 Rohingya have arrived in Aceh and faced some hostility from fellow Muslims.

Indonesia, like Thailand and Malaysia, is not a signatory to the United Nations' 1951 Refugee Convention so is not obligated to accept the Rohingya.

So far, refugees in distress have received at least temporary accommodation.



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA/TRN

Artistes performing Newari traditional dance at the 25th anniversary of the Nepal Tourism Board in Kathmandu on Sunday.

Dallu Awas Festival concludes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

The first-ever 'Dallu Awas Festival – Jatra Yatra ko' (a series of musical festivals promoting Newar culture and music) concluded successfully on Saturday. The event organised by Shree Ganesh Samudayik Bikash Sewa in collaboration with Funologic Solutions took place on a street of Dallu Awas in Kathmandu.

The one-day festival that began with the cultural dhime performance by a group of artists dressed in Newari cultural attire concluded with the musical performances by singer Kuma Sagar and the Khopa Band.

Rojal Shahi, the managing director of Funologic Solutions, said that the main goal of the festival was to promote the Newar community, its traditions and music.

He said, "Yatra Jatra ko will experience a series of musical events in the future across the county. Dallu Awas Festival is the first in this series. Similar to it, we will be organising events to support Newa artists and provide platforms for newcomers."

In the event, singer Ujan Shakya performed his superhit numbers 'Rajamati chaa', 'Oh Maicha' and others. Similarly, singers Roj Man Maharjan and Nisha Deshar won the hearts of audiences with their duet song 'Aila Luwaya', the song which has become popular with people from all linguistic background. It severs the flavour of dohori to Newari music, which is not common to the Newari music industry.

Similarly, Niva Dangol performed several numbers including 'Sachika China'. She is an emerging singer and her song titled 'Sachika China' became popular among all Nepalis despite language barriers.

The festival also showcased performances such as the traditional Kumari and Bajrayogini dance and a comedy drama – 'Dha Sa Dhala Dhai' (Newari youtube series).

The event provided a platform for the local bands to participate and witnessed an overwhelming response from locals. The event also included various food stalls including stalls of authentic Newari cuisine like yomari and samaybaji.



PHOTO: TRN

Singer Kuma Sagar performing at Dallu Awas Festival.

Paula Abdul accuses 'American Idol' producer Nigel Lythgoe of sexual assault in lawsuit



AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 31

Paula Abdul has accused former "American Idol" producer Nigel Lythgoe of sexually assaulting her in the early 2000s when she was a judge on the reality competition show, according to a new lawsuit.

The lawsuit filed Friday in Los Angeles also accuses Lythgoe of sexually assaulting Abdul after she left "American Idol" and became a judge on Lythgoe's other competition show "So You Think You Can Dance."

The Associated Press generally does not identify alleged victims of sexual assault unless they come forward publicly, as Abdul has done.

In a statement Saturday, Abdul's lawyer Douglas Johnson applauded the singer and dancer for speaking out publicly.

"It was clearly a difficult decision to make, but Ms. Abdul knows that she stands both in the shoes and on the shoulders of many other similarly situated survivors, and she is determined to see that justice is done," Johnson said.

Lythgoe said in a statement that he was "shocked and saddened" to hear of the allegations made by Abdul, who he said he considered a "dear" and "entirely platonic" friend.

"While Paula's history of erratic behavior is well known, I can't pretend to understand exactly why she would file a lawsuit that she must know is untrue," Lythgoe said in the statement. "But I can promise that I will fight this appalling smear with everything I have."

The lawsuit states Abdul remained silent for years about the alleged assaults out of fear of retaliation by "one of the most well-known producers of television competition shows."

Before "American Idol" and "So You Think You Can Dance," on which Lythgoe served as a judge for 16 seasons, he was a producer on the British show "Pop Idol," which became a global franchise that includes the U.S. iteration starring Abdul.

According to the lawsuit, the first sexual assault occurred while Abdul and Lythgoe were on the road filming auditions for an earlier season of "American Idol," which premiered in 2002.

Abdul says Lythgoe groped her in the elevator of their hotel after a day of filming and "began shoving his tongue down her throat." Abdul pushed him away and ran to her hotel room when the elevator doors opened.

"In tears, Abdul quickly called one of her representatives to inform them of the assault," the lawsuit says, "but ultimately decided not to take action for fear that Lythgoe would have her fired from American Idol."

Abdul, a Grammy- and Emmy-winning artist, starred as a judge for the first eight seasons, leaving in 2009.

In 2015, Abdul became a judge on "So You Think You Can Dance," appearing alongside Lythgoe.

Around that time, Abdul alleged in the lawsuit, Lythgoe forced himself on top of her during a dinner at his home and tried to kiss her. Abdul said she again pushed Lythgoe away and immediately left. Abdul left the reality show after two seasons. She has not worked with Lythgoe since.

The lawsuit also accuses Lythgoe of taunting Abdul about the alleged assaults, saying to her years later that "they should celebrate" because "the statute of limitations had run."

Abdul filed the suit days before the Dec. 31 deadline of a California law that opened a one-year window for victims to file lawsuits involving sexual abuse claims after the statute of limitations has run out.

BRITISH ACTOR TOM WILKINSON DIES AT 75

AP
London, Dec. 31

Tom Wilkinson, the Oscar-nominated British actor known for his roles in "The Full Monty," "Michael Clayton" and "The Best Exotic Marigold Hotel," has died, his family said. He was 75.

A statement shared by his agent on behalf of the family said Wilkinson died suddenly at home on Saturday. It didn't provide further details.

Wilkinson was nominated for a best actor Academy Award for his work in 2001's family drama "In The Bedroom" and in the best supporting actor category for his role in "Michael Clayton," a 2007 legal thriller that starred George Clooney.

He is remembered by many in Britain and beyond for playing former steel mill foreman Gerald Cooper in the 1997 comedy "The Full Monty," about a group of unemployed steel workers who formed an unlikely male stripping act.

Wilkinson was born in Yorkshire in northern England in 1948 and spent part of his childhood in Canada. He attended the Royal Academy of Dramatic Art in the 1970s.

He starred in dozens of other TV dramas and movies, from "Rush Hour" and "Batman Begins" to "Shakespeare in Love," "Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind" and "Valkyrie." He most recently reunited with his "Full Monty" co-stars, Robert Carlyle and Mark Addy in a Disney+ series of the same name.

"He'll be sorely missed by everyone who had the pleasure of working with him," Carlyle said in a statement. "Such a huge performer, a real titan of an actor, one of the greats of not only his, but of any generation."

Wilkinson was recognized for his services to drama in 2005 when he was appointed a member of the Order of the British Empire.

Nirvik brings 'Tyasari Ta Kahilyai Sochiena'



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec.31

Those who passed by may not be in touch again
If in touch, they may not be as they were
We could keep them near
By grasping with the embrace of smile
But never did we think in that way

These lines of poetry are by young poet Nirvik Jung Rayamajhi who has come up with his debut anthology of poetry 'Tyasari Ta Kahilyai Sochiena' (Never Did I Think In That Way).

Famous poets Shyamal, Bhupal Rai and Momila Joshi released the book amid a function in the capital on Saturday.

Shyamal found creative lunacy within Nirvik while reading his poetry. "Normal people can do only normal things but for the creation, you must have creative madness," he said. He assumed that the book would be a powerful intervention on the status quo.

Poet and Chancellor of Nepal Academy Rai got the promising talent in Nirvik's poetry while Momila felt celebrating the festival of poetry while reading the poetry by Rayamajhi.

"His poetry has the rich talent to express more in few words," she opined.

London-based poet and journalist Rayamajhi has many poems, essays and news reports to his credit. The book consists of 50 poems of diverse flavours.

Published by Kalam Publications, Kathmandu, the book costs Rs. 375.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: The unknown may have you feeling as though your life is careening around uncontrollably. Even if you normally know where you're going and what the end goal is from the start.

Taurus: All might not be peaceful in your connections with others. You could find that other people in your life, especially those in business partnerships with you, are mismanaging your ideas -- they potentially.

Gemini: Being bossy probably won't get you across your desired finish line. The urge to be in charge of those around you could crop up without warning, but acting on it would only work.

Cancer: Your routine might be getting stagnant. You want to break free, but you still have responsibilities, and so you may feel caught between a rock and a hard place instead of sliding into a productive groove.

Leo: Risks don't always come with rewards. Someone may be talking up a precarious opportunity, potentially gambling, an investment, or something else, as long as it isn't a sure bet. No matter how delightful the potential reward sounds, keep in mind that it isn't likely.

Virgo: There may be a disagreement between someone in your biological family and someone who's in your life by choice. These people might not see eye to eye, and you may not know who to side with -- or if you should pick a side at all.

Libra: There may be a disagreement between someone in your biological family and someone who's in your life by choice. These people might not see eye to eye, and you may not know who to side with -- or if you should pick a side at all.

Scorpio: You may be struggling with two paths. One side of you could be called to the road more traveled, following paths where others have found success, while the other half of your heart wants to forge a path that peers have been too afraid or uninspired to blaze.

Sagittarius: To lead your own story or follow history's examples? You might feel left out in the cold for leaving the traditional path of your family or culture, inciting alienation or loneliness.

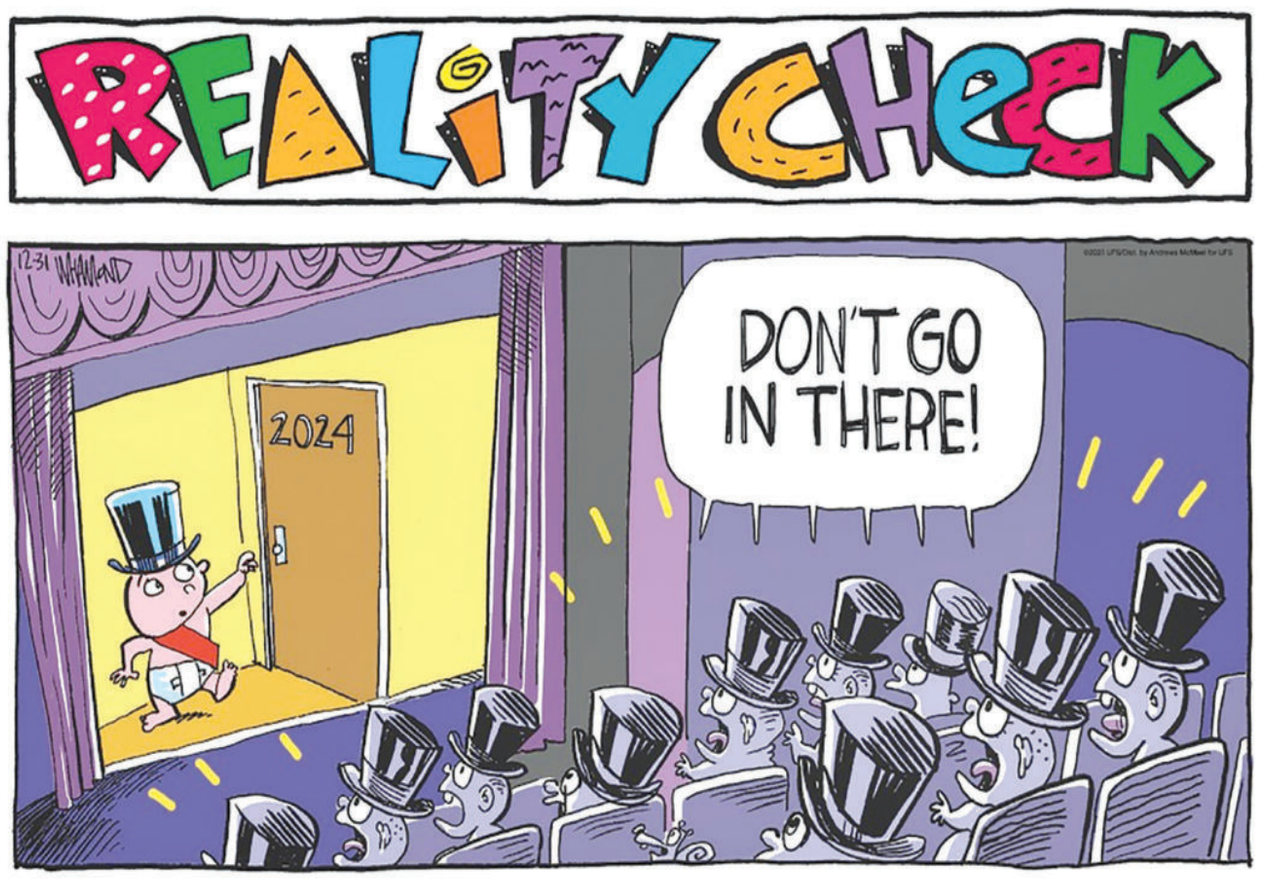
Capricorn: Your energy levels might be foiling you today. It's possible that you're feeling run-down due to recent overexertion or simple illness. Either way, you may not want to tell people that you won't be able to be there for them like you were hoping.

Aquarius: To listen to one person or the group? At present, there may be a close confidant in your ear saying one thing to you, but you might also encounter a larger group of people telling you the complete opposite.

Pisces: Who you want to be may not be similar to the person others presently want you to be. There might be a strong push for you to conform, either in your workplace or another public area where who you are reflects on the overall group.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Koshi and Sudur Pashchim competing today for a place in finals against APF



PHOTO: BIKAS/TRN

Players of Sudurpaschim Province celebrates after winning their Eliminator match against Bagmati Province during the PM Cup Women's T20 National Cricket Tournament, Kirtipur, Sunday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 31

Losing the match by 52 runs on Sunday, Koshi will now play against Sudur Pashchim at Qualifier 2 today. Sudur Pashchim marched towards a place in the finals after defeating Bagmati Province at Eliminator 1 held Sunday evening.

On the other hand, Armed Police Force (APF) has become the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament's major contender once again. Title-defender APF booked its place in the finals after winning at Qualifier 1 against Koshi Province on Sunday.

It will be a good competition on the English New Year's Day between the second and third-positioned Koshi and Sudur Pashchim respectively. The winner will face APF for the cup on January 3, 2025.

Electing to bat first in the morning match at the Tribhuvan University (TU) International Cricket Ground, APF posted a target of 140 in the loss of two wickets. A half-century by Indu Barma, who remained not out, and Sita Rana Magar's 45 off 37 balls helped APF reach 139 by the end of 20 overs.

Rubina Chhetry became the only bowler for Koshi to claim a wicket. APF bowlers could also not take enough wickets, but they prevented Koshi batters from reaching the target.

After playing all 20 overs in the run chase, Koshi could only score 87 in the loss of four wickets. Apsari Begam was Koshi's highest scorer with 31 off 48 followed by Rubina Chhetry's 22 off 26.

Sita, who was only five runs short of a half-century, claimed a wicket by giving only nine runs with the bowl. Rekha Rawal also claimed a wicket for APF giving only 11 runs.

The contest in the Eliminator round also saw a proficient half-century by Bindu Rawal as she helped Sudur Pashchim win against Bagmati. Rawal, who hit seven fours, remained not out at 54 runs off 49 balls with Samjhana Khadka (21 runs off 16 balls). Sudur Pashchim won by nine wickets as they chased the target of 100 in 14.3 overs. Rubi Poddar also departed after scoring 18 runs for Sudur Pashchim.

With one over remaining, Bagmati was bowled out at 99 runs as Karishma Thapa took three wickets, and Laxmi Saud and Ritu Kanoujiya took two wickets each. Kanchan Shrestha was Bagmati's highest scorer with 36 runs off 46 balls.

Aston Villa, Man City close on Premier League lead

AFP
Manchester, Dec. 31

Douglas Luiz's late penalty took Aston Villa joint top of the Premier League with a 3-2 win over 10-man Burnley on Saturday as Manchester City closed on the leaders by sweeping aside Sheffield United 2-0.

But Manchester United's thrilling comeback to beat Villa on Boxing Day proved to be a false dawn for Erik ten Hag's men as they slumped to a 2-1 defeat at Nottingham Forest.

It looked like a festive season to forget for Villa was set to continue after dropping points at home for the first time this season to Sheffield United and blowing a 2-0 lead to lose 3-2 at United.

However, Luiz's spot-kick, that crept in off the underside of the bar, sent Unai Emery's men level on points with Liverpool at the top of the table.

Leon Bailey's opener for the home side was quickly cancelled out by Zeki Amdouni for Burnley.

Moussa Diaby restored Villa's lead before half-time and they had a man advantage for the final 35 minutes after Sander Berge saw a second yellow card.

But Villa's high line is begging to be picked off by opponents and Lyle Foster timed his run to blast past Emi Martinez 19 minutes from time.

There was a final twist, though, as Jhon Duran was upended inside the box and Luiz fired home.



PHOTO: AP

Aston Villa's Ollie Watkins, left, and Burnley's Dara O'Shea battle for the ball during the English Premier League soccer match against Burnley in England.

Man City cruise

Despite missing Erling Haaland for a seventh consecutive game due to a foot injury, City were never troubled by the bottom-of-the-table Blades.

Rodri ended Sheffield United's resistence after just 14 minutes when the Spanish midfielder surged forward and fired low into the far corner.

Julian Alvarez again ably filled Haaland's shoes as the Argentine tapped in his fourth goal in three games to make the points safe from Phil Foden's cross just after the hour mark.

City move alongside Arsenal on 40 points, just two points behind Villa and Liverpool, who are in action at home to Newcastle on Monday.

United, by contrast, are 11 points off the top after losing for the 21st time in 2023.

A second win in three games under Nuno Espirito Santo lifts Forest five points clear of the relegation zone.

Nicolas Dominguez swept the home side in front after a well-worked move on 64 minutes.

Marcus Rashford rolled home only his third goal of the season after Alejandro Garnacho pounced on an error from Forest goalkeeper Matt Turner to level with United's first away goal in four games. But the Red Devils were quickly cut open on the counter-attack as Anthony Elanga teed up Morgan Gibbs-White to fire home the winner from outside the box.

Palmer inspires Chelsea

Chelsea snapped a run of four consecutive away defeats thanks to Cole Palmer's double but had to withstand a nervy finale to beat Luton 3-2.

Powerful strikes from Palmer and Noni Madueke gave the visitors a 2-0 half-time lead.

Mauricio Pochettino's men appeared to have ridden out a second half storm when Palmer's classy finish made it 3-0.

But former Chelsea midfielder Ross Barkley sparked a Luton revival and Elijah Adebayo bundled home from close range to set up a thrilling finale.

Luton remain just one point adrift of safety as Everton slumped to a 3-0 defeat at Wolves.

Any fears that Crystal Palace could be dragged into the relegation battle were eased by the Eagles first win in nine games as Brentford were beaten 3-1 at Selhurst Park.

SNIPPETS

Nadal leaves door open

Brisbane (AFP): Rafael Nadal left the door ajar Sunday to continuing after the 2024 season, but conceded there was "a high percentage" that he was on his last trip as a player to Australia. Speaking ahead of his comeback from a 12-month injury absence at the season-opening Brisbane International, the 37-year-old Spaniard said he did not know for sure what the future held. "The problem about saying that's going to be my last season is I can't predict what's going on 100 percent in the future," he said. "I can't predict how I'm going to be in the next six months."

Juventus close on Inter

Rome (AP): Juventus ended a troubled year on a positive note after beating Roma 1-0 to close in on Serie A leader Inter Milan on Saturday. Adrien Rabiot scored and Juventus moved within two points of Inter, which drew on Friday. Ju1ventus broke the deadlock right at the start of the second half. Rabiot beat the offside trap to latch onto a cheeky Dušan Vlahovic back-heeled flick and slot into the bottom near corner. AC Milan also ended the year with a victory — after a difficult month — in edging Sassuolo 1-0.

Madrid extends Ancelotti's contract

Madrid (AP): Real Madrid has extended Carlo Ancelotti's contract until 2026, seemingly ending Brazil's hopes of hiring him as the new national coach. Ancelotti had been linked with a move to Brazil for months, with the president of the Brazilian Football Confederation publicly expressing his desire to hire the Italian. But Ancelotti had said all along that he would like to remain at Madrid if the club wanted him. His current contract was to expire at the end of this season.

NZ share T20 series 1-1 with Bangladesh

AP
Mount Maunganui, Dec. 31

Mitchell Santner and Jimmy Neesham combined in a 46-run partnership which steered New Zealand to a 17 run win over Bangladesh under the Duckworth-Lewis system in the third Twenty20 international on Sunday, dashing the Tigers' hopes of their first series win in New Zealand.

Captain Santner and Neesham provided the cool heads New Zealand needed to overcome another top-order collapse and chase down Bangladesh's inadequate total of only 110 in a race against encroaching dark clouds and rain.

New Zealand was in desperate trouble at 49-5 in the ninth over, trailing under the Duckworth-Lewis system when Neesham and Santner came together.

They stayed together and guided New Zealand to 95-5 in the 15th over when the forecast rain arrived torrentially and brought the match to an abrupt end.

"I think we always knew there was going to be a bit of rain around whether it came at the end of halfway through that second innings," Santner said. "The bowlers did the job up front and it was good to get across the line in a pretty hard-fought series."

In extraordinary scenes, spectators dashed for the exits of Bay Oval as the rain pelted down, driven by strong winds. New Zealand needed 78 runs to be ahead on the Duckworth-Lewis calculation.

Sunday's win leveled the three-match series at 1-1 after Bangladesh won the first match by five wickets and after the second match at Bay Oval was washed out after 11 overs.

But New Zealand can no longer turn a blind eye to the failings of its top order in the ongoing absence of Kane Williamson and Devon Conway.

Bangladesh may have lost the three-match one-day international series and shared the T20 series, but it achieved its first wins in New Zealand in both formats.

Polarising Warner draws curtain on 12-year Test career

AFP
Sydney, Dec. 31

David Warner exits Test cricket this week as one of the best openers the world has known, but his exploits will forever be overshadowed by the role he played in the notorious ball-tampering scandal of 2018.

The polarising 37-year-old Australian will pad up for an emotional farewell at the Sydney Cricket Ground in the third Test against Pakistan after a career that began when he faced New Zealand at Brisbane in 2011. In his 111 Tests, the left-hander has plundered 8,695 runs at an average of 44.58, with 26 centuries and 36 half-centuries. A larger-than-life character, Warner also collected 89 catches as one of the most consistent slip fielders in the game.

"He is probably our greatest ever three-format player. He'll be a loss," Australian coach Andrew McDonald said on Saturday.

"Other people have been gunning for him for a period of time but for us, internally, we've seen the great value and what he brings to the table, hence why we've kept picking him. "It can be hard to replace someone who is striking at 70, averaging 45, most ever runs as an Australian opener."

But Warner, who plans to continue in white-ball cricket, has made enemies along the way, with former Australian quick bowler Mitchell Johnson letting rip ahead of the Pakistan series. "Yes, he has a decent overall record and some say is one of our greatest opening bats," he said.

"But his past three years in Test cricket have been ordinary, with a batting average closer to what a tail-ender would be happy with. "It's the ball tampering disgrace in South Africa that many will never forget."



Remorseful

Warner's dark side came into play as the chief plotter in the 'sandpaper-gate' scandal in South Africa, which shattered a reputation already bruised by numerous run-ins.

Along with skipper Steve Smith, he was banned for a year by Cricket Australia for his part in the third Test debacle in Cape Town that saw Cameron Bancroft use sandpaper to scuff the ball before a crude attempt to conceal the evidence down his trousers.

Part of the punishment saw Warner stripped of the vice-captaincy and banned from ever leading the team, crushing his dream of captaining Australia's one-day side.

For many in the game, the assertive Warner's involvement was hardly a surprise.

In June 2013, he was suspended and fined for punching England's Joe Root in a Birmingham bar on the eve of the Ashes.

"I'm extremely remorseful. I have let my teammates, Cricket Australia, the fans, myself and my family down," said Warner at the time.

Two months earlier, he was similarly contrite after an ugly Twitter spat with two Australian journalists.

But his trademark combative nature never dimmed.

In the opening Test in Durban ahead of the ball-tampering fiasco, he and Quinton de Kock squared up to each other, with Warner claiming the home wicket-keeper had made "vile and disgusting" remarks about his wife Candice. Warner was fined 75 percent of his match fee and De Kock 25 percent.

Despite the controversies, he was welcomed back into the Australia fold when his ban ended, and made his Test comeback during the Ashes series against England in 2019. It was a miserable return, scoring just 95 runs in 10 innings at a paltry average of 9.5 while being repeatedly booed by English fans. But selectors again kept faith and he bounced back later that year with an unbeaten 335 against Pakistan in Adelaide and has been ever present since.

Former Australia captain Greg Chappell said Warner would "never live down the sandpaper-gate incident", but he urged people to look past it to his overall contribution to the team spanning more than a decade.

"Whatever one thinks of him, David Warner has been fantastic for Australian cricket," he wrote in the Sydney Morning Herald this weekend.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:20 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas and mainly fair in rest of the country. Possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.7	5.3	0.0
Dipayal	25.2	7.3	0.0
Dhangadi	26.1	10.0	0.0
Birendranagar	24.0	7.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.0	12.2	0.0
Jumla	17.7	-3.7	0.0
Ghorahi	23.6	10.0	0.0
Pokhara	22.7	10.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.6	10.7	0.0
Simara	27.2	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.4	7.8	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.6	8.8	0.0
Taplejung	17.6	6.6	0.0
Dhankuta	23.9	10.4	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	12.6	0.0
Jomsom	11.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	26.8	14.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.0	7.2	0.0*
Janakpur	30.5	12.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.4	2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 1, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.84	Rs. 133.44
Euro	1	Rs. 146.62	Rs. 147.28
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.12	Rs. 169.88
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 157.82	Rs. 158.54
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.48	Rs. 90.89
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.28	Rs. 100.73
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.67	Rs.101.13
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.42	Rs. 9.46
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.71	Rs. 18.79
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.42	Rs. 35.58
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.44	Rs. 36.60
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.86	Rs. 3.88
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.17	Rs. 36.33
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.91	Rs. 29.04
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.26	Rs. 10.30
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.19	Rs. 13.25
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.67	Rs. 19.76
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.01	Rs. 17.09
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.35	Rs. 434.30
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.36	Rs. 353.95

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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